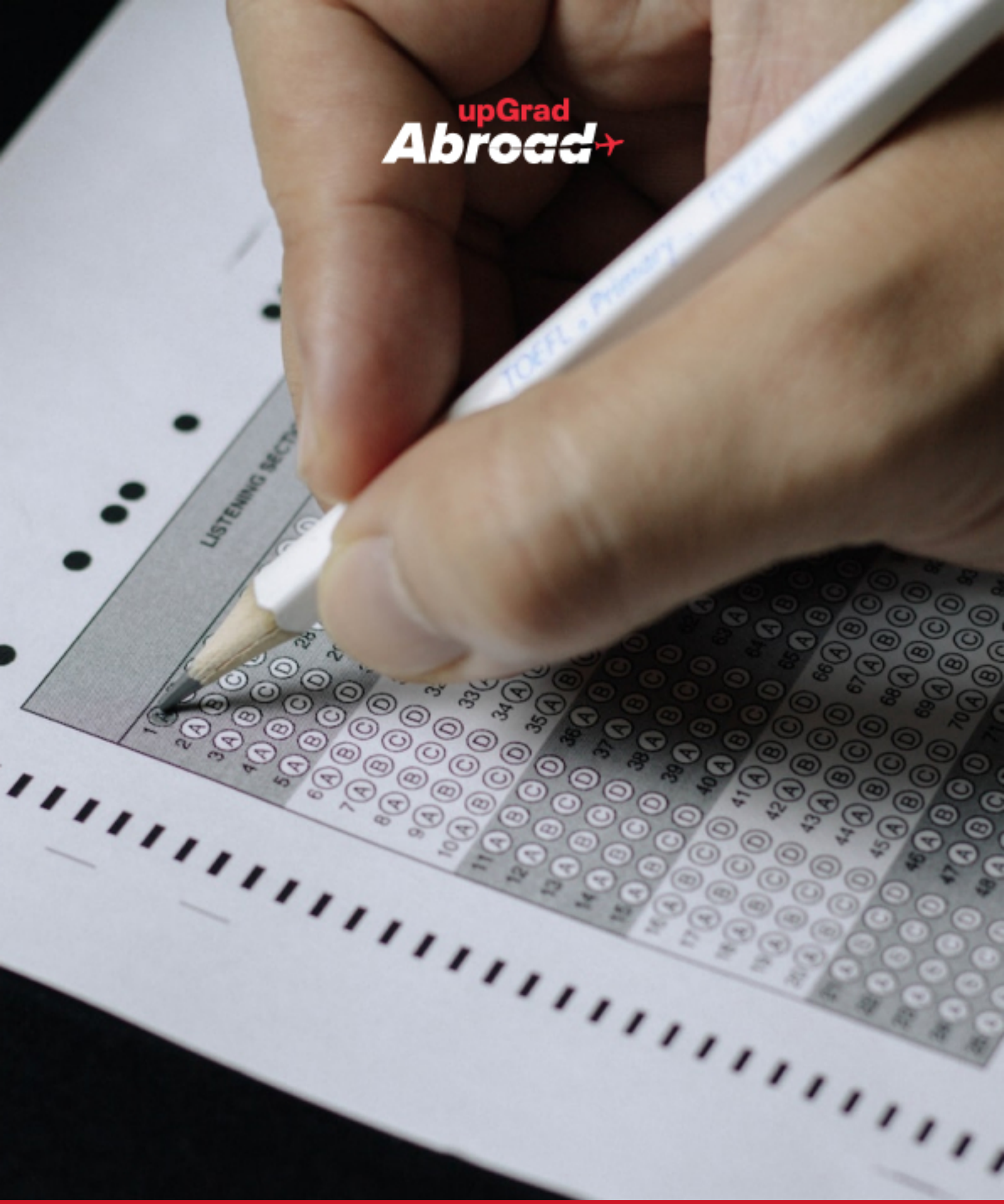

SAT Exam Syllabus 2026

The SAT Exam Syllabus 2026 follows the Digital SAT format, combining Reading & Writing (short passages, grammar, vocabulary in context, evidence) and Math (Algebra, Advanced Math, Data Analysis, Geometry/Trigonometry, with calculator allowed throughout). Key skills tested include evidence, structure, conventions, expression, and core math concepts such as linear functions, quadratics, probability, and data interpretation.

This guide covers a detailed SAT **(Scholastic Assessment Test)** syllabus, section-wise breakdown, scoring pattern, recent changes, and practical study tips for students.

> ***Grab the latest SAT syllabus e-book from upGrad, your roadmap to Reading, Writing, and Math success is just one click away.***

SAT Exam Syllabus Outline

The SAT exam syllabus outline is designed in a manner that the exam measures the competence of a student at the college level. The test is in a digital, adaptive version, so every section requires 2 modules. The way you do the first module will determine the level of difficulty of the second. This design aids in measuring ability without making the test very long.

Key points of the SAT exam syllabus outline:

- **Sections:** Evidence-Based Reading & Writing (EBRW) and Math
- **Duration:** 134 minutes total
- EBRW: 64 minutes
- Math: 70 minutes
- **Modules:** Two per section (adaptive)
- **Scoring:** Each section is scored on a scale of 200–800; the combined total ranges from 400–1600
- **Format tools:** Digital interface includes an on-screen calculator (for Math calculator module), timer, question flagging, and annotation options

Also Check: SAT Exam Pattern 2026

Detailed SAT Syllabus (Section-wise Topics)

The complete SAT syllabus is separated into three major parts, which are Reading, Writing and Language, and Math. All sections have clearly outlined content areas, skills being measured, and the type of questions.

The revised SAT syllabus will include the breakdown of each syllabus as shown below.

SAT Reading Syllabus

The SAT reading syllabus evaluates how well students can analyse written material across subjects.

Content Areas:

- **Literature:** Prose passages from U.S. and world literature, focusing on themes, character analysis, and narrative structure.
- **History/Social Studies:** U.S. founding documents, speeches, or discussions of social science topics like economics, sociology, or political science.
- **Science:** Topics from biology, chemistry, physics, or earth sciences. Passages often include tables, graphs, or charts.

Skills Tested:

- Identifying central ideas, themes, and supporting details
- Understanding word meaning and vocabulary in context
- Drawing inferences and evaluating evidence
- Analysing arguments and author's perspective
- Integrating text with visual data (charts/graphs)

Question Types:

- Evidence-based questions requiring specific proof from the passage
- Identifying main ideas and supporting details
- Interpreting data from charts or tables tied to passages
- Function of words or phrases in context

SAT Writing and Language Syllabus

The SAT writing and language syllabus focuses on editing and improving texts for clarity and correctness.

Content Areas:

- **Grammar and Usage:** Verb tense, pronoun use, subject-verb agreement, modifiers
- **Punctuation:** Commas, semicolons, colons, apostrophes, dashes

- **Sentence Structure:** Parallelism, subordination, coordination, run-ons, fragments
- **Expression of Ideas:** Organization, logical transitions, style, and tone

Skills Tested:

- Command of evidence: selecting words, phrases, or sentences that improve meaning
- Making sentences more concise and clearer
- Improving logical flow in a passage
- Recognizing and correcting grammatical errors

Question Types:

- Error identification (grammar, punctuation, sentence structure)
- Sentence and paragraph improvement
- Passage-level editing (adding or removing content for clarity)

SAT Math Syllabus

The SAT math syllabus is divided into two modules, one that allows calculator use and one that does not. It measures both foundational and advanced problem-solving skills.

Content Areas:

1. **Heart of Algebra:**
   - Linear equations and inequalities
   - Systems of linear equations
   - Linear functions and graphs
1. **Problem-Solving and Data Analysis:**
   - Ratios, proportions, and percentages
   - Descriptive statistics (mean, median, mode, standard deviation)
   - Probability and data interpretation
   - Working with scatterplots, histograms, and graphs
1. **Passport to Advanced Math:**

- Quadratic equations and functions
- Polynomials and rational expressions
- Exponential and radical equations
- Nonlinear equations and systems

1. **Additional Topics in Math (Geometry & Trigonometry):**

- Circles, triangles, angles, and polygons
- Coordinate geometry
- Basic trigonometric functions (sine, cosine, tangent)
- Volume and area calculations

Skills Tested:

- Algebraic manipulation and problem-solving
- Applying math concepts to real-world problems
- Quantitative reasoning and data analysis
- Using graphs and functions to model situations

Question Types:

- **Multiple-choice:** Four answer options
- **Grid-in (student-produced response):** Students provide their own numerical answers

Calculator vs. Non-Calculator Modules:

- **Non-Calculator Module:** Tests mental math, algebra, and reasoning without computational help
- **Calculator Module:** Involves more complex problem-solving, data interpretation, and multi-step calculations

Also Read: ***SAT Registration 2026 – Dates, Fees, Step-by-Step Guide & Tips***

SAT Syllabus Changes You Should Know

The syllabus and structure of the SAT exam have been hugely revised over the last few years. These changes to the SAT syllabus influence the way students study the test and how colleges use scores.

1. Transition to the Digital SAT

- The SAT is now completely digital, replacing the traditional paper-and-pencil test.
- The digital version is adaptive, meaning each section has two modules. Your performance in the first module influences the difficulty of the second.
- The overall test length has been reduced to 134 minutes (shorter than the previous 3-hour version), making the exam more focused and less tiring.
- Digital features include:
- An on-screen calculator (available throughout the Math calculator module)
- Question flagging to review later
- Built-in annotation tools
- The adaptive structure allows a more precise measurement of skills while ensuring a faster, more personalized experience.

2. Essay Discontinued

- The optional SAT Essay was removed in 2021.
- Colleges now assess writing ability through:
- The Writing and Language section of the SAT
- College application essays
- Supplemental writing samples (if required by the institution)
- This change reduces the time and cost of the exam while streamlining the SAT syllabus for students.

3. Subject Tests Retired

- The SAT Subject Tests in areas like Math, Literature, Biology, Chemistry, and World History were permanently discontinued.
- Students aiming to demonstrate subject mastery are now encouraged to submit AP (Advanced Placement) or IB (International Baccalaureate) exam scores or highlight coursework achievements.
- This change aligns with the move toward a simpler SAT exam syllabus outline that focuses on critical reading, writing, and math skills.

Also Read: ***SAT Exam Eligibility: Your Complete Guide to 2026 Requirements***

SAT Test Syllabus Overview (Format + Scoring)

The SAT test syllabus overview explains how the exam is structured, how it is scored, and how the digital adaptive format ensures fairness for all test-takers.

Exam Duration and Structure

- **Total Duration:** 134 minutes
- **Sections:** Evidence-Based Reading & Writing (64 minutes) and Math (70 minutes)
- **Modules:** Each section has **two modules**. The first is a mix of easy, medium, and hard questions; performance here determines the difficulty level of the second module.

Number of Questions

- **EBRW:** Around 54 questions spread across the two modules
- **Math:** Around 44 questions across calculator and non-calculator modules
- **Total:** Approximately 98 questions in the entire test

Scoring Method

- Each section (EBRW and Math) is scored on a scale of 200–800
- Combined total score ranges from 400–1600
- No negative marking for wrong answers; only correct answers contribute to the score

Adaptive Difficulty Explained

- The digital SAT is adaptive by section:
- If a student performs well in the first module, the second will present more challenging questions.
- If performance is lower, the second module will contain more moderate-level questions.
- This ensures the test is shorter while still accurately reflecting skill level.

Fairness in Scoring

- Even though the test adapts to performance, the College Board uses equating to ensure fairness.
- Scores are comparable across different test dates and versions, so a 1400 on one version of the SAT is equivalent to a 1400 on another.
- Adaptive scoring is designed to maintain consistency and fairness worldwide.

Also Read: ***SAT Requirements for Top 25 US Schools***

8-Week Study Plan Based on the Updated SAT Syllabus

It takes concentration and organization to prepare in only two months to take the SAT. This is a plan that addresses the SAT math syllabus, SAT reading syllabus, and SAT writing and language syllabus, and is balanced with content review, practice, and test strategy.

Week 1: Diagnostic Test and Planning

- Take a full-length digital SAT on the College Board's Bluebook app.
- Identify strengths and weaknesses by section: Reading, Writing, Math.
- Break down weak areas (e.g., algebra vs. geometry, grammar vs. sentence improvement).
- Set weekly study goals based on diagnostic results.

Week 2: Core Math: Algebra & Problem-Solving (Part 1)

- Review Heart of Algebra: linear equations, inequalities, systems of equations.
- Practice Problem-Solving & Data Analysis: ratios, percentages, descriptive statistics.
- Focus on non-calculator problems to build accuracy and speed.
- Solve 25–30 targeted practice questions daily.

Week 3: Core Math: Advanced Math & Geometry (Part 2)

- Study Passport to Advanced Math: quadratic equations, polynomials, exponential functions.
- Revise Geometry and Trigonometry: circles, triangles, coordinate geometry, sine/cosine basics.

- Mix calculator and non-calculator practice sets.
- Take one mini adaptive math module under timed conditions.

Week 4: Reading Comprehension + Writing and Grammar

- **Reading:**
- Practice literature, history/social studies, and science passages.
- Work on evidence-based questions and data interpretation.
- **Writing:**
- Review grammar rules (punctuation, verb tense, modifiers).
- Focus on sentence structure, clarity, and conciseness.
- Daily practice: 2 passages (Reading) + 20 grammar questions (Writing).

Week 5: Timed Practice Sets Across Sections

- Solve mixed practice sets (20–25 questions) with a timer.
- Work on pacing: average 52 seconds per reading/writing question and 75 seconds per math question.
- Track accuracy rates for each topic.
- Start simulating exam-day conditions with quiet study sessions.

Week 6: Digital SAT Adaptive Practice

- Take full adaptive modules in Bluebook to mimic the real test.
- Practice using the on-screen calculator, annotation tools, and question flagging.
- Analyse module transitions (easy → `harder or easier second module).`
- Focus on accuracy in the first module since it determines the second’s difficulty.

Week 7: Strengthening Weak Spots

- Revisit weakest areas from Weeks 1–6 (e.g., trigonometry, inference questions, punctuation).
- Use targeted drills for 20–30 minutes daily.

- Review test strategies:
- Process of elimination
- Guessing intelligently (no negative marking)
- Flagging tough questions and returning later
- Take one full-length SAT by the weekend.

Week 8: Final Full-Length Practice and Review

- Take two full-length practice SATs under strict timing.
- Mimic exam-day routine: sleep early, timed breaks, no distractions.
- Review each test thoroughly, analyse not just wrong answers but also lucky guesses.
- Revise formulas, grammar rules, and reading strategies.

Must Read: ***Best SAT Preparation Books 2026***

Best Resources to Prepare for the SAT Exam Syllabus

The planning of the SAT should be done based on a combination of credible materials that meet the new SAT syllabus. Although the official College Board and Khan Academy resources are free, authentic, and official, thousands of students are also using organized paid products such as Kaplan, Princeton Review, and Barron's.

The resources that are trusted most are highlighted in the following table, their type, cost, and who they are most applicable to. This will provide students with a choice according to their objectives and budgets in terms of their studies.

Resource	Cost	Best For
College Board (Official Site)	Free	Access to the official SAT exam syllabus outline, Bluebook app, and real practice tests
Khan Academy	Free	Personalized practice aligned with the updated SAT syllabus, lessons, and progress tracking
Kaplan SAT Prep Plus	Paid	Students who want structured strategies and section-wise practice
Princeton Review SAT Prep	Paid	Balanced coverage of SAT math syllabus, SAT reading syllabus, and SAT writing syllabus
Barron’s SAT Study	Paid	In-depth review and additional practice for high-score aspirants

Guide		

Also Read: ***SAT Preparation: How to Prepare for SAT Exam***

Conclusion

The sat exam syllabus may look vast, but breaking it into Reading, Writing and Language, and Math makes it much more approachable. As the digital SAT introduces adaptive testing, students should rely on official resources instead of just coaching versions like the pw sat syllabus to avoid confusion.

Using the official sat syllabus as your study roadmap ensures you stay aligned with what the test measures. Be sure to give extra attention to the sat exam maths syllabus, since strong math skills can significantly boost your overall score. Pairing the syllabus with reliable tools like College Board and Khan Academy makes preparation both focused and effective.

Get started with upGrad's expert guidance to craft a study plan tailored to your strengths and goals.

About upGrad Abroad

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